

Activity 1: Study One App and Analyze It

Title of Activity: Ethical Analysis of a Mobile Application

Name of Mobile App Studied: WhatsApp

Student Details

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Q1. Introduction

WhatsApp is a widely used mobile messaging application developed by Meta. It allows users to send text messages, make voice and video calls, share images, documents, locations, and other media over the internet.

The main purpose of WhatsApp is to provide fast, simple, and secure communication globally. Its key features include end-to-end encryption, group chats, voice/video calling, status updates, and file sharing.

Q2. Privacy and Data Protection

WhatsApp uses **end-to-end encryption**, which means only the sender and receiver can read the messages. Even WhatsApp cannot access the content of chats.

However, it does collect some metadata such as phone number, device information, and usage data. Ethical concerns arise regarding how this data may be shared with its parent company (Meta) for service improvement and business analytics.

Q3. User Consent and Transparency

WhatsApp asks users to agree to its **Terms of Service and Privacy Policy** before using the app.

Permissions like contacts, camera, microphone, and storage access require user approval.

Transparency is important because users must clearly understand how their data is being used.

Although policies are provided, many users accept them without reading, which raises ethical concerns about informed consent.

Q4. Security vs Social Responsibility

WhatsApp ensures strong security through encryption, protecting user privacy.

However, this same security can sometimes be misused for spreading misinformation, fake news, or illegal activities because messages cannot be monitored.

This creates a balance challenge between protecting privacy and ensuring public safety.

Q5. Social Impact of the Application

Positive Impacts

1. Enables instant global communication at low cost.
2. Helps in education, business communication, and emergency coordination.

Negative Impacts

1. Spread of misinformation and fake news through forwarded messages.
 2. Overuse may lead to reduced face-to-face interaction and digital addiction.
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Q6. Ethical Evaluation

From an ethical perspective, WhatsApp performs well in **privacy protection** through encryption and secure communication.

However, concerns remain regarding **data sharing policies, misinformation control, and user awareness**.

The company has taken steps like message forwarding limits and reporting tools to improve responsible usage.

Q7. Conclusion

WhatsApp is an ethically designed communication platform with strong security features that protect user privacy. While it provides major social and technological benefits, responsible use and better awareness are necessary to reduce misuse.

Overall, WhatsApp can be considered ethically responsible, but continuous improvements in transparency, data handling, and misinformation control are essential.
